The Measurement of Discrimination and Inequality

Syllabus

Course Details

Instructor	Lennart Ackermans
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Office	Ludwigstraße 31, Room 129
Office Hours	By appointment
Seminar Room	Ludwigstraße 31, Room 021
Time	Mondays, 16:00-18:00 c.t.

Description

We will examine the conceptual and methodological challenges involved in measuring inequality and discrimination across the social sciences. Measuring inequality and discrimination is a difficult endeavour in which each methodological choice is also an ethically loaded choice. Students will get acquainted with approaches from social sciences such as economics and sociology, and will also read recent texts from philosophers who have entered the debate. Particular attention will be given to the causal structure of concepts like inequality of opportunity, algorithmic unfairness, and discrimination, and to the causal measurement problems to which this gives rise.

Students will learn to read social-scientific studies with a critical eye. The goal is to gain a sophisticated understanding of methodological, conceptual, and ethical problems associated with these studies.

As with most societally relevant topics, it is to be expected that students disagree, sometimes vehemently, with some of the literature and with each other. In the in-class discussions, our goal will be to understand these disagreements on a deeper level.

The course starts with an introduction to causal measurement using the potential outcomes framework and Judea Pearl's graphical framework. We then dive into several specific measurement topics. Students have a say in which topics to discuss, as I have not decided on the entire syllabus in advance. To give your opinion you can talk to me personally after class, or send me an email.

This is a list of topics we might discuss: inequality of opportunity, income inequality, pay gaps between groups, wealth inequality, gender inequality, labour market discrimination, discrimination in the criminal justice system, and algorithmic unfairness.

This syllabus will be updated every week with the readings for the subsequent week. Please always consult the latest version, available at https://lennart.phd/teaching/.

Please always download the readings using the links in the syllabus or my weekly email. This ensures that we have the same version and page numbers.

Requirements

1. **Prepare for the seminars.** You are expected to read the assigned readings and think about them. Please come to the seminar with at least one question about the readings.
2. **Give a presentation.** In week 12 (11 January) and possibly week 13, we will hold a student colloquium where each of you will give a presentation. The grade for the presentation counts towards the final grade with 30%. The length of your presentation can be up to 15 minutes.

   Please let me know your preferred topic by 30 November.
3. **Write a term paper based on your presentation.** The recommended length is around 4000 words. There is no lower and upper limit. The grading criteria are available here. The same criteria apply to bachelor and master students, but bachelor students are graded more leniently.

   It is possible to submit an initial version of your paper for feedback (ungraded). **Please do so by 22 February 2027.**

   The deadline for submitting the term paper is 22 March 2027.

Seminar Schedule

Session	Topic and Readings
Week 1	*Introduction and Causal Measurement*
12.10.2026	In the first two weeks we will read excerpts from Morgan and Winship's textbook in causal inference methods. The goal is to gain a rudimentary understanding of what causal measurement involves and why it is difficult. You do not need to understand these methods to the extent that you can apply them (as would be required in a statistics course). **Required readings** • Morgan, S. L., & Winship, C. (2014). *Counterfactuals and Causal Inference: Methods and Principles for Social Research* (2nd ed.). Cambridge University Press. Sections 1.1 and 1.2 from Chapter 1. Sections 2.1–2.4 of Chapter 2. **Further readings**

	• Pearl, J. (2009). *Causality: Models, Reasoning, and Inference* (2nd ed.). Cambridge University Press. Download • Birkelund, G. E., Lancee, B., Larsen, E. N., Polavieja, J. G., Radl, J., & Yemane, R. (2022). Gender discrimination in hiring: Evidence from a cross-national harmonized field experiment. European Sociological Review, 38(3), 337–354. Download • González, M. J., Cortina, C., & Rodríguez, J. (2019). The role of gender stereotypes in hiring: A field experiment. European Sociological Review, 35(2), 187–204. Download
Week 2 19.10.2026	*Causal Graphs* **Required readings** • Morgan, S. L., & Winship, C. (2014). Counterfactuals and Causal Inference: Methods and Principles for Social Research (2nd ed.). Cambridge University Press. Chapter 3. Section 4.1 and 4.2 from Chapter 4. **Further readings** • Imbens, G. W. (2020). Potential outcome and directed acyclic graph approaches to causality: Relevance for empirical practice in economics. Journal of Economic Literature, 58(4), 1129–1179. Download • Markus, K. A. (2021). Causal effects and counterfactual conditionals: contrasting Rubin, Lewis and Pearl. Economics and Philosophy, 37(3), 441–461. Download • Ackermans, L. B. (2023). Reflections on the 2021 Nobel Memorial Prize Awarded to David Card, Joshua Angrist, and Guido Imbens. Erasmus Journal for Philosophy and Economics, 16(1), 77–96. Download